demonetization would cripple the opposition parties, thus facilitating a BJP victory in this important state.[25]

Another was that Prime Minister Modi wished to be seen as taking strong action against black money. Former supporters of the Prime Minister, such as veteran lawyer Ram Jethmalani, had been vocal in criticizing him for not keeping his 2014 election promise on black money: 'The one promise he had made was that ₹90 lakh crore of black money was concealed in foreign banks and that he will get back that money and give ₹15 lakh to the family of every poor man…'[26]

A third theory was that the decision was taken to divert attention from a potentially disastrous revelation that could affect the reputation of the Prime Minister. It was given credence by the allegation by the Delhi CM, on the floor of the Delhi legislative assembly on 15 November, that documents seized during raids by the income tax department purported to show that the Prime Minister had received bribes during his tenure as the Chief Minister of Gujarat. On the same day, senior advocate Prashant Bhushan, through his NGO Common Cause, filed a petition in the Supreme Court (SC) presenting the data from these income tax raids, requesting action against those whose names featured in the documents.[27]

The allegations and documents were reminiscent of the infamous 'Jain Hawala diaries' case. In 1991, a businessman, S.K. Jain, was arrested. During the search of his residence, a handwritten diary was recovered which contained notations of payments amounting to ₹65 crore made to 115 individuals. The recipients' names were written in code, but they matched the initials of some of the senior-most political leaders of the country. In a landmark judgement related to this case, the Supreme Court ruled in 1997: 'Whenever any record indicating illegal payments to public functionaries is recovered by any government agency, a thorough and independent investigation must be undertaken.'[28]

During the course of the next few weeks, Rahul Gandhi, the leader of Congress, and Sitaram Yechury, leader of the CPI(M), reiterated the